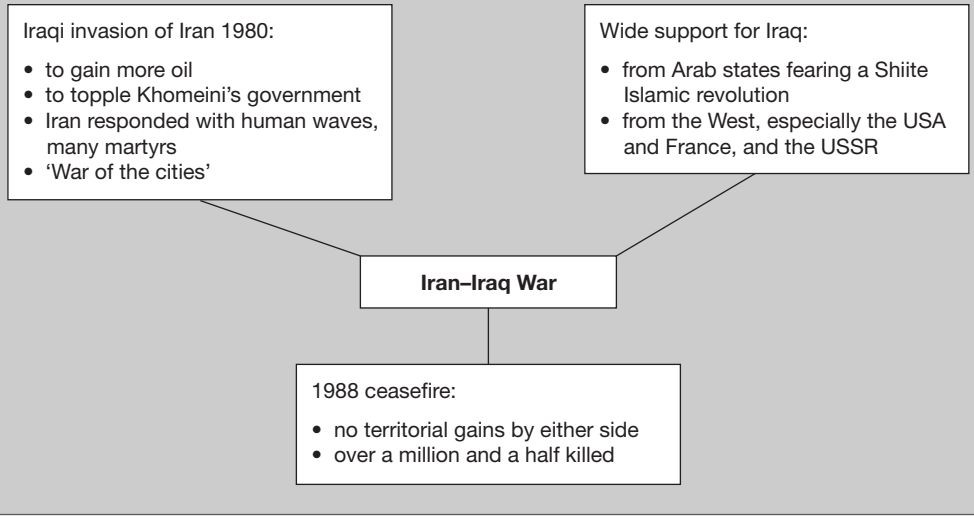
feared what might happen to their families if they went over to the other side.

Khomeini said that agreeing to a ceasefire was a decision which he found 'more deadly than poison'. He died a year later in 1989. Despite eight years of warfare, in which hundreds of thousands had died, he was still revered by millions of Iranians for his proud, defiant stand after years of humiliation by stronger powers. Twelve million people filled the streets of Tehran for his funeral, lining the streets leading to the cemetery. The Islamic Republic continued to attract wide support in Iran.

Although Iran suffered massive destruction and loss of life, it had a population of 55 million and was still a major power. However, it had not succeeded in exporting its revolutionary, Shiite brand of Islam.

Iraq's economy and society had also suffered huge damage. Not only had half a million people been killed, but the health and education of the entire population suffered. During the war, more and more was spent on weapons (accounting for 93 per cent of all imports by 1984) so less and less was spent on hospitals and schools. Life expectancy fell and infant mortality increased. Yet, despite all the suffering in this long war, Iraq went to war again within two years.

Summary diagram: The Iran–Iraq War 1980–8